Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction

ISSN: 0011-1619 (Print) 1939-9138 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/vcrt20

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To cite this article: Fang Tang (23 Dec 2025): Forgetting to remember: Amnesia as Metaphor in Chinese North American Literature, Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction, DOI: 10.1080/00111619.2025.2608218

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/00111619.2025.2608218

Published online: 23 Dec 2025.

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CRITIQUE: STUDIES IN CONTEMPORARY FICTION
https://doi.org/10.1080/00111619.2025.2608218

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Forgetting to remember: Amnesia as Metaphor in Chinese North American Literature

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ABSTRACT

By undertaking a comparative study of Amy Tan's *The Bonesetter's Daughter* (2001) and Zhang Ling's *Gold Mountain Blues* (2011), this paper examines how amnesia functions as a metaphor and narrative strategy for reimagining Chinese diasporic identity. Departing from its clinical connotations, amnesia emerges as a dynamic condition through which diasporic subjects negotiate belonging, loss, and continuity. In Tan's novel, forgetting operates as an intimate site of intergenerational repair, enabling the reconstruction of familial and cultural ties. Zhang, by contrast, mobilizes amnesia as a collective and historical framework that traces the dispersal and partial recovery of Chinese identities across transnational and temporal divides. Through this juxtaposition, the study argues that amnesia, rather than a void, is a palimpsestic space where silence and narration intersect, revealing memory as an ongoing act of rewriting that sustains continuity within diasporic fragmentation.

Introduction

Memory, shaped through lived experience, forms the foundation for recalling the past, interpreting the present, and envisioning the future. It provides the temporal continuity through which identity is constructed and made intelligible (Ricoeur, 1992, p.118). As psychologist Daniel Schacter (1996) observes, memories form "the core of our life stories," shaping our sense of self and belonging (p.299). Yet memory is never confined to individual consciousness; it is mediated by cultural, social, and historical frameworks that give personal recollection meaning and structure. German cultural memory theorist Jan Assmann (2008) conceptualizes this as a dynamic interplay between individual and collective memory, where remembering is an act of cultural performance rather than a simple retrieval of the past (p.109). Equally integral to this process is forgetting, which Paul Ricoeur (2004) frames not as the negation of memory but as its condition of possibility – a "reserve" enabling memory to be renewed and reinterpreted over time (p.35). Remembering and forgetting operate as intertwined processes of selection, determining which histories are preserved and which are effaced. Jacques Le Goff (1992) describes this selective process as "organized forgetting," whereby collective amnesia sustains hegemonic historical narratives (p.54). In diasporic contexts, memory serves as a site of continual negotiation between remembrance and amnesia, testimony and silence, for cultural identity is continuously reconstituted. As migration entails rupture, it destabilizes the narrative and spatial continuities that anchor the self. Nicolas Pethes (2019) captures this paradox: "cultural memory is always a form of cultural oblivion," for beneath institutionalized remembrance lie multiple suppressed or unrealized possibilities (p.101). Diasporic memory is thus marked by fragmentation, displacement, and mediation, as the past is reconstructed through the gaps and dislocations of exile.

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In literary studies, these theoretical insights have been productively applied to postcolonial and diasporic literature. Literature transforms memory from a psychological or historical category into an aesthetic and ethical practice that reimagines how the past is silenced, narrated, and transmitted across generations. Within diasporic fiction, remembering and storytelling are inseparable, as narrative becomes a means of negotiating the fractures of displacement and the silences of historical trauma. Contemporary scholarship increasingly conceptualizes memory in literary narratives as performative practice with significant ethical implications. Pethes (2019) emphasizes the moral stakes embedded in narrative acts of remembering, while Jade Tsui-yu Lee (2020) situates memory work in Asian American literature within framework of "minor transnationalism," arguing that recollection travels laterally across marginalized histories rather than conforming to dominant, nation-centered narratives. Furthermore, Scott Small (2021) demonstrates how strategic forgetting functions as a critical resource through which diasporic subjects negotiate and reclaim agency over inherited trauma. These approaches underscore memory as an active and contested mode of cultural production, which is a premise this study builds upon to examine how amnesia and selective remembrance operate as narrative strategies of survival and ethical reorientation.

Within Chinese diasporic literature in North America, the interplay of remembering and forgetting has become a defining mode of narrative self-fashioning. Writers such as Maxine Hong Kingston, Amy Tan, Jung Chang, Ha Jin, and Geling Yan illustrate how diasporic subjects reconstruct continuity amid linguistic estrangement, historical fracture, and exile. Kingston's *The Woman Warrior* (1976) and *China Men* (1981) establish an early paradigm in which cultural memory functions simultaneously as inheritance and burden. Amy Tan's *The Joy Luck Club* (1989) and Jung Chang's *Wild Swans* (1991) foreground maternal memory as both transmission and distortion, emphasizing its role in negotiating generational and cultural gaps. Across this corpus, memory emerges as a resource for reconstructing cultural identity. Rewritten through fragmentation, silence, dissonance, and partial transmission, memory in diasporic fiction becomes an imaginative reconstruction shaped by loss and displacement. Although scholarship has extensively engaged with memory in these works, comparatively little attention has been given to the role of forgetting and amnesia, and how these processes produce distinctive narrative strategies across different diasporic locations and historical experiences.

It is against this backdrop that the present study undertakes a comparative reading of Amy Tan's *The Bonesetter's Daughter* (2001) and Zhang Ling's *Gold Mountain Blues* (2011),[1] with its aim of examining how both authors reconfigure the dialectic of remembering and forgetting as intertwined narrative and ethical strategies. Scholarly engagement with Tan's work has been extensive, addressing her depictions of mother-daughter relationship (Kordel, 2014), negotiation of transnational identity and cultural hybridity (Feng, 2014; Walsh, 2017), and storytelling as a means of cultural remembrance (Wong, 1997; Lotfi, 2014). In contrast, critical discussion of Zhang's fiction remains relatively limited but thematically significant. Ruo-qian Pu and Yang Song (2012) view *Gold Mountain Blues* as a diasporic epic that integrates individual and collective memory to reconstruct the Chinese immigrant experience. Lin Pei-yin (2014) highlights Zhang's "melodramatic imagination" as a narrative strategy of merges historical realism with intuitive invention; Yifan Jin (2025) situates her cosmopolitan stance within a translingual framework of Sino-Canadian cultural exchange. Despite these contributions, few studies have placed Tan and Zhang in direct dialogue, leaving underexplored how both authors mobilize remembrance and forgetting to articulate diasporic identity. This essay thus aims to address two central questions: How do Chinese diasporic authors reimagine the relationship between remembering and forgetting in the construction of diasporic identity? And how do their narratives transform memory and amnesia into aesthetic strategies for bridging generational, linguistic, and historical discontinuities? In exploring these questions, the paper argues that while Tan emphasizes the psychological reconstruction of fractured ancestral memory, Zhang foregrounds historical endurance and collective reclamation through embodied memory. Both authors reveal the paradoxical function of amnesia within diasporic consciousness, where erasure enables recovery and forgetting serves as a prelude to remembrance. Through this comparison, the study demonstrates how

contemporary Chinese diasporic literature reimagines identity through the unstable interplay of memory and forgetting.

Forgetting to be Remembered: Amnesia, Assimilation, and Cultural Reclamation

Both *The Bonesetter's Daughter* and *Gold Mountain Blues* interrogate the entanglement of memory, amnesia, and identity within intergenerational Chinese immigrant narratives in North America. The mothers in these novels, LuLing and Yin Ling, each suffers from Alzheimer's disease and subsequent amnesia, conditions that compel their Westernized daughters to reconstruct family histories and cultural heritage long obscured by silence, migration, and assimilation. In both cases, Alzheimer's and amnesia transcend their neurological dimensions to function as metaphors for fragmented subjectivities and for the cultural amnesia precipitated by displacement. By dramatizing memory loss as both psychological disintegration and cultural negotiation, both texts reveal how immigrant subjects grapple with disjunction between personal remembrance and collective inheritance. The daughters' reconstruction of maternal memory thus becomes a process of re-anchoring identity and reclaiming the suppressed genealogies of diaspora.

In *The Bonesetter's Daughter*, Tan extends the oral storytelling tradition in Chinese American literature by embedding it within written archives, highlighting the symbolic and material significance of ink, manuscripts, and textual preservation in sustaining cultural memory. The novel is organized into five sections, including a prologue, a three-part main body, and an epilogue, creating a dialogic interplay between first-person and third-person narration. The first-personal narrative is voiced by eighty-two-year-old LuLing Young, whose memory is increasingly eroded by Alzheimer's disease. Positioned as the pivotal link between three generations, her mother, a Chinese woman called Precious Auntie, who is the daughter of a bonesetter, and her American-born daughter Ruth Luyi Young, LuLing mediates the transmission of memory across linguistic, temporal, and cultural divides. The third-person narrative traces the intertwined experiences of three generations. Their overlapping stories navigate linguistic, temporal, and cultural thresholds. This alternating structure generates a palimpsestic narrative, in which personal recollection and collective history continually revise one another. Storytelling in the novel functions as a compensatory act. By reassembling fragmented and often unreliable memories, the women impose narrative coherence upon psychic disarray. In doing so, remembering becomes a form of reconciliation that restores both maternal intimacy and cultural continuity. LuLing's memoir, rooted in the Liu family's lineage of ink-making, is haunted by Precious Auntie, whose disfigurement and muteness after swallowing molten ink render her simultaneously spectral and inexpressible. Precious Auntie's silenced body becomes a living archive of trauma, embodying patriarchal violence as well as the unspeakable residue of grief transmitted across generations. LuLing's own migration from war-torn China to postwar America repeats this pattern of rupture: her efforts to reconstruct herself through linguistic and cultural assimilation results in estrangement from both her native and adopted worlds.

In contrast, Zhang's *Gold Mountain Blues* situates memory within a multigenerational diasporic framework that spans more than a century of Chinese Canadian experience. Beginning with Fong Tak-Fat's migration as a railway laborer in 1879 and extending to the late twentieth century, the novel charts the enduring tension between cultural preservation and the seductions of assimilation. This conflict culminates in the fourth generation, Fong Yin Ling, whose psychological disintegration exposes the corrosive effects of internalized colonial discourse. Confronted by racial hierarchies and economic precarity, Yin Ling seeks legitimacy through the repudiation of her Chinese origins, her pursuit of whiteness manifesting most acutely in her relation to language. The novel captures her linguistic alienation: "She spoke Cantonese at home with her family, but she still labored under a handicap; she could neither read nor write Chinese" (Zhang, 2017, p.408). The inability to sustain literacy in her native tongue encapsulates the psychic cost of assimilation. Her fluency in English secures social intelligibility yet intensifies alienation from both homeland and host culture. Zhang thus

transforms linguistic erosion into critique of cultural survival under racial capitalism, where mastery of the dominant language confers access but never belonging.

The contrast between Yin Ling and LuLing reveals divergent linguistic responses to diaspora. Whereas Yin Ling rejects Chinese in her pursuit of assimilation, LuLing clings tenaciously to Mandarin as the last vestige of identity. In Tan's novel, this linguistic stubbornness becomes a central metaphor for the ambivalence of cultural attachment. LuLing's halting "choppy English" and her inability to communicate fluently with others mark her as both comically foreign and tragically isolated. As Ruth recalls, LuLing's white tenants complain, "I don't know what she's talking about, but she goes on and on, like a broken record" (Tan, 2001, p.50). LuLing's linguistic insufficiency isolates her within the immigrant community. Ruth observes that her mother's quarrels often arise from "poor English. She didn't understand others, or they didn't understand her" (Tan, 2001, pp.44–45). LuLing's linguistic deficiency functions simultaneously as vulnerability and resistance: while it excludes her from mainstream participation, it also preserves an unassimilated cultural core. Frantz Fanon's insight that "to speak a language is to take on a world, a culture" (2008, p.25) underscores how linguistic dissonance encodes colonial hierarchies. Yin Ling's abandonment of Chinese and LuLing's imperfect English represent inverse but equally fraught attempts to navigate linguistic imperialism. Both trajectories expose the limits of assimilation. In a racialized society, fluency in English may enable survival, but it rarely secures recognition.

This divergence extends further to their attitudes toward family names and lineage, another axis along which memory and identity intersect. In *The Bonesetter's Daughter*, as LuLing's Alzheimer's progresses, she grapples with a haunting void in recollection: "There is one name I cannot remember. It is there in the oldest layer of my memory, and I cannot dig it out" (Tan, 2001, p.1). What appears as a moment of cognitive failure in fact registers as a profound crisis of genealogical continuity. Within diasporic consciousness, the family name functions not merely as a signifier of kinship but as a mnemonic vessel, preserving collective memory, cultural inheritance, and the moral order of lineage. Stripped of this linguistic anchor, LuLing's maternal history drifts into her mother's absence: "She had existed, and yet without a name, a large part of her existence was missing, could not be attached to a face, anchored to a family" (Tan, 2001, p.335). Maurice Halbwachs (1992) elucidates this function of naming in the constitution of social memory, observing that names mediate between the individual and the collective, linking intimate recollection to the broader structures of familial remembrance: "Nothing serves us better than first names to indicate this kind of recollection, which is based neither on general notions nor on individual images, but which nevertheless refers to a kinship link and to a specific person simultaneously" (p.71). Through LuLing's futile yet persistent search for her mother's lost surname, Tan dramatizes an ethics of remembrance within the diasporic condition. To name is to resist erasure, to write is to re-inscribe lineage against the silences of migration and the amnesia of assimilation.

By contrast, Yin Ling's trajectory in *Gold Mountain Blues* reveals a conscious repudiation of her surname as part of her fraught negotiation with assimilation and proximity to whiteness. Convinced that marriage to white man will secure her emancipation from racial marginalization, she confines her romantic pursuits to white partners, conflating intimacy with whiteness with the promise of social mobility and belonging, even though the illusion of liberation only intensifies her vulnerability. Her boyfriend, Johnny, conceals her Chinese origin by claiming she is the daughter of a Frenchman and a Vietnamese woman, a fabrication that literalizes her erasure from both cultural and genealogical identity. When a landlady dismisses her as "Chinese trash" (Zhang, 2017, p.438), Yin Ling's silence betrays not mere resignation but the internalized shame of one who longs for inclusion within a structure that perpetually denies her subjecthood. Her serial relationships with white men trace a cycle of self-effacement, revealing how the pursuit of acceptance within a racialized hierarchy paradoxically reinforces her social precarity.

The birth of her mixed-race daughter, Amy, outside of marriage, epitomizes the intergenerational reverberations of racial exclusion. Perceiving her ethnicity as a liability, Yin Ling symbolically severs the link to her ancestry by replacing the family name with the generic "Smith." This act of renaming

extends beyond pragmatic concealment; it performs a symbolic violence against her lineage, dramatizing the psychic toll of self-erasure under racial capitalism and colonial modernity. Whereas LuLing's amnesia in *The Bonesetter's Daughter* registers the involuntary fragility yet stubborn endurance of memory, Yin Ling's conscious abandonment of her surname reveals the internalization of cultural negation. Their divergent responses delineate two intersecting modalities of diasporic subjectivity: one rooted in the unconscious dissolution of memory while the other in the willed erasure of identity, yet both conditioned by the assimilative demands and racial hierarchies of the host culture.

Despite their divergent approaches to assimilation, both women succumb to Alzheimer's disease, experiencing a comparable trajectory of cognitive dissolution in which the fabric of their present realities in North America become increasingly muddled, while long-suppressed ethnic memories resurface with uncanny vividness. This paradoxical inversion, forgetting the present while recovering the past, binds memory loss to a site of cultural reawakening. The erosion of cognitive functions a conduit through which ancestral memory, long repressed by assimilationist pressures, reclaims narrative authority. For LuLing, the early symptoms of Alzheimer's appear through mundane yet revealing disruption of daily life: she forgets to lock doors, leaves food to spoil, neglects bills, and misnames familial objects, such as calling a ribbon as "wrapping paper" and an envelope as a "stamp" (Tan, 2001, p.46). These linguistic slippages and pragmatic failures register both the physiological decline confirmed by medical diagnosis and a deeper symbolic dislocation. Her cognitive fragmentation mirrors the psychic disorientation of the immigrant who inhabits a culture not her own. As the language and logic of the present dissolve, what surfaces is a return to the affective substratum of cultural belonging. Her amnesia, therefore, operates as a metaphorical process of recovery. By forgetting the assimilated self-imposed by Western modernity, LuLing accesses a residual layer of cultural memory, which asserts itself precisely through the act of forgetting.

While LuLing's memory of quotidian life in America rapidly deteriorates, the long-buried recollections of her homeland resurface with startling clarity. What assimilation had once suppressed returns in a surge of unmediated affect. Ruth, long accustomed to her mother's confusion and silence, is astonished by moments of sudden lucidity in which LuLing speaks with precision and emotional depth about her Chinese past. Ruth reflects that "the pathways to her mother's past were still open, though rutted in a few spots and marked by rambling detours" (Tan, 2001, p.345). These moments complicate conventional alignment of dementia with loss or erasure. For LuLing, the erosion of recent memory does not signify the disintegration of self but rather its reorganization around a repressed cultural consciousness. Her defiant assertion, "Nothing wrong my memory! I'member lots things, more than you" (Tan, 2001, p.96), articulates a refusal of biomedical authority and an insistence on the persistence of an alternative, affective knowledge grounded in ancestral experience.

The juxtaposition between her accelerated forgetting of America and her sustained retention of China dramatizes a paradoxical form of cognitive return. As her mind detaches from the present, LuLing turns inward, retracing the traumatic landscapes of her youth and reconstructing the silenced history of Precious Auntie and her family. As Naeimeh Tabtabaei Lotfi (2014) points out, "The haunting power of past memories, intensified in traumatic incidents, forces the individuals to create an eligible picture of past; this would ensure a secured sense of 'self'" (p.1912). LuLing's dementia, in this light, exceeds the medical model of decline; rather, it functions as an act of psychic preservation in which trauma becomes the organizing grammar of identity. Although Alzheimer's collapses temporal coherence, her memories of China remain vivid, sustained, and emotionally charged. They provide her not with nostalgic regression but ontological continuity, and a reassertion of belonging that transcends the temporal and spatial dislocations of migration.

Yin Ling's experience with amnesia parallels LuLing's in its exploration of cultural identity, yet it unfolds through a distinct narrative logic. After her seventy-ninth birthday party, a stroke leaves Yin Ling comatose and, upon awakening, she is diagnosed with Alzheimer's disease and partial amnesia. The earliest symptom emerges through language. Once fluent in English, she awakens unable to comprehend the speech of doctors and nurses. As the novel describes: "Now, bizarrely, it was as if some tiny perverse hand had meddled in her brain, erasing it all" (Zhang, 2017, p.4). The erasure of

English here functions as more than a symptom of neurological damage: it dramatizes the unmaking of the assimilated self. The language that once promised access to whiteness and social mobility becomes the first casualty of cognitive dissolution. Involuntary unlearning thus assumes the force of symbolic renunciation, exposing the instability of an identity predicated upon linguistic and cultural substitution. Despite her lifelong efforts to efface her ethnic origins, the novel intimates that the diasporic subject cannot fully escape the gravitational pull of cultural memory. Identity, it suggests, is not a matter of conscious will but of a sedimented affect and embodied remembrance. In the aftermath of her stroke, Yin Ling begins to speak in an incomprehensible language that the hospital staff attribute to neurological damage. Amy recognizes that this "nonsense" is, in fact, Cantonese, the dialect of Yin Ling's childhood. This unexpected reversion to her mother tongue dramatizes the persistence of cultural memory within the unconscious, surfacing precisely when the mechanisms of rational control collapse. As her speech reverts, so too does her temperament. She grows volatile, quarrelsome, and resistant to the discipline of predominantly white rehabilitation institutions that had once defined her horizon of belonging. Unable to manage her mother's outbursts, Amy eventually transfers her to a Chinese nursing home. Immersed once again in familiar language, cuisine, and ritual, Yin Ling gradually regains a measure of emotional equilibrium. Her newfound calm underscores the profound entanglement between psychic stability and cultural embeddedness. In contrast to her earlier pursuit of assimilation, her late-life reversion to Chinese language and custom signifies a return to the very cultural matrix she had once repudiated.

Through Yin Ling's involuntary return to her native language and her rejection of white institutional authority, *Gold Mountain Blues* underscores the inescapable pull of cultural heritage in shaping diasporic identity. Language, as postcolonial theorist Homi Bhabha (2002) argues, mediates the "coming-to-consciousness" of cultural identity, functioning as both the locus of belonging and the boundary of exclusion (p.206). Within this framework, amnesia in both novels destabilizes the linguistic foundation upon which selfhood has been constructed, compelling both characters to renegotiate and reconstruct their identity. Gayatri Spivak's (1996) concept of "clearing space" provides a useful lens for interpreting this transformation. She argues that the bilingual subject must "clear a space, step away, spit out the mother tongue" (pp.21–22) in order to achieve a critical distance from inherited language. This statement implies that linguistic estrangement is not incidental but intrinsic to the formation of postcolonial subjectivity. In both novels, however, amnesia reverses this trajectory. Rather than a deliberate "clearing of space," the involuntary displacement of English allows the suppressed mother tongue to resurface, providing an affective and mnemonic foundation for self-recognition. In this way, forgetting operates not as loss but as a productive mechanism that recuperates inherited language and cultural identity. As Andreas Huyssen (1995) explains, forgetting is seldom a simple erasure; rather, it manifests through distortion, repression, and the selective silencing of traumatic experience (p.7). In both novels, the fragile psychic equilibrium produced by the interplay of remembering and forgetting collapses under the mothers' Alzheimer's-induced amnesia. Yet within this paradox, forgetting becomes productive which allows each woman to recover what assimilation and displacement had sought to silence, revealing the enduring intimacy between language, memory and cultural survival.

Memory as Mnemonic Resistance: Storytelling and the Reinscription of History

As discussed in the previous section, both *The Bonesetter's Daughter* and *Gold Mountain Blues* center on mothers afflicted with Alzheimer's disease, through whom the authors explore the tension between remembrance and oblivion within diasporic consciousness. Despite their differing approaches, Tan and Zhang converge in their use of material artifacts, including letters, manuscripts, and everyday objects, inscribed with the traces of the past, as mnemonic mediators between generations. Through the daughters' acts of reading, interpreting, and discovering their mothers' stories, these artifacts become instruments of self-discovery and a rearticulation of identity across temporal and cultural divides. In *The Bonesetter's Daughter*, Tan departs from the oral storytelling tradition that shaped her

earlier works, turning instead to the written archive as the locus of recovery. The act of writing becomes an instrument of mnemonic resistance, preserving ancestral memory against the erasures imposed by migration, assimilation, and neurological decline. In so doing, Tan allows family memory to extend beyond the intimate sphere and assume broader cultural significance (Lotfi, 2014, p.1915). In this novel, Tan continues to probe the conflicts and reconciliations of the mother–daughter relationships, situating these within a haunted transnational landscape where China, both real and imagined, operates as a spectral geography, a repository of family secrets and suppressed histories that illuminate the protagonists' American present (Feng, 2014, p.328).

In the novel, as LuLing's amnesia intensifies, her turn to manuscript writing becomes a deliberate effort to preserve family history, and a means of transforming fragile personal memoirs into enduring archival forms. This impulse toward documentation is amplified through the discovery of Precious Auntie's letters and diaries, which serve as intergenerational conduits that bridge the temporal and spatial ruptures of migration. Through these written remnants, LuLing affirms her mother's existence and actively resists the erasure of memory, safeguarding the continuity of her familial and cultural heritage against the erosions of time and displacement. Precious Auntie's rhetorical question, "what is the past but what we choose to remember?" (Tan, 2001, p.352), encapsulates the dialectic of remembrance and forgetting, suggesting that memory, when mediated through writing, becomes both a protective and reconstructive strategy within diasporic experience. This dynamic aligns with Cathy Caruth's (1995) conception of trauma as belated experience that is known only through its deferred and mediated return. Tan's narrative enacts this belatedness through LuLing's fragmented recollections and recursive storytelling, in which the past continually resurfaces in partial, textual forms. By framing writing itself as the medium through which trauma is belatedly encountered and rearticulated, the novel transforms the act of narration into a mode of working through loss.

Moreover, writing functions as an act of agency through which LuLing resists the historical silencing of women by patriarchal and cultural forces. As her manuscripts are translated into English with the help of Mr. Tang, LuLing recovers her mother's full name, including the maternal surname "Gu." Phonetically linked to "bone," this surname becomes a powerful symbol of both familial continuity and the ancestral vocation of bone-setting, transforming the act of naming into a reclamation of lineage and identity across three generations of women. Complementing this linguistic and symbolic recovery is the novel's recurring motif of the oracle bone, a tangible relic that simultaneously serves as a personal memento and an emblem of cultural heritage. As LuLing claims, "It had belonged to my mother, my grandfather. It was my connection to them" (Tan, 2001, p.287). The bone's dual function, as genealogical repository and historical marker, enables Tan to illustrate how memory, anchored in material and symbolic objects, persists across generations despite dislocation and forgetting, "Precious Auntie belonged to a family. LuLing belonged to that same family, and Ruth belonged to them both. The family name had been there all along, like a bone stuck in the crevices of a gorge" (p.196). By interlacing the material artifact of the bone with the linguistic signifier of the surname, Tan ensures the transmission of collective identity across temporal and generational divides.

Through the revelation of the family name and lineage, the novel situates LuLing's China stories within the looser and shifting dialogic frame of Ruth's narrative. Ruth, raised in the United States and fluent in English, might be expected to serve as a linguistic and cultural bridge between LuLing and the world around her. However, their relationship is instead characterized by persistent miscommunication and emotional estrangement. Ruth experiences a deep sense of discomfort and shame toward her mother's overtly "Chinese" behavior. She resents her mother's linguistic awkwardness as an obstacle to assimilation into American society. Ruth's frequent misinterpretations of her mother's words underscore a deeper disjunction between the first-generation immigrants and American-born descendants. When LuLing complains about urine stains left by a dog, Ruth responds by asking about a black-and-white cat, entirely misconstruing her mother's intention. The clash between filial obligation and Western individualism becomes most pronounced when LuLing attempts to read Ruth's diary, prompting Ruth's indignant protest: "I'm an American [...] I have a right to privacy" (Tan, 2001,

p.140). Ruth's assertion reflects not merely adolescent defiance but also the internalization of Western liberal ideals, which stand in contrast to her mother's collectivist sensibility.

The widening rift between mother and daughter, marked by Ruth's rejection of her mother's cultural otherness and her own quiet marginality within American society, establishes the emotional and thematic groundwork for the novel's final revelation. Confronting her mother's cognitive decline becomes, paradoxically, the moment through which Ruth attains clarity about her own obscured identity. This belated recognition is foreshadowed in childhood, when at the age of six, Ruth feigns muteness after a schoolyard accident. Using a chopstick to inscribe messages in the sand, she experiences both the empowering substitution of written words for speech and the painful awareness that only through such self-effacement can she elicit her mother's compassion. This voicelessness persists into her adulthood, as Ruth works as a ghostwriter for contemporary inspirational texts, her professional voice remaining in the shadow of others' authorship. Each August, she symbolically "loses her voice" again, a ritualized return to silence that she associates with the cosmic spectacle of meteor showers. The significance of this cyclical muteness remains latent until the moment when Ruth, having her mother's manuscript translated from Chinese, finally comprehends the affective logic of her mother's words. What once appeared as control now reads as care, "these warnings were passed down, not simply to scare her, but to force her to avoid their footsteps, to hope for something better" (Tan, 2001, p.352). As Tabatabaei Lotfi (2014) suggests, the act of sharing memories embodies a will to overcome the silence imposed by trauma, especially within migrant families where language barriers obstruct direct communication (p.143). By reading and reinterpreting of her mother's manuscript, Ruth transforms silence into understanding, and moves from resistance to empathy, from alienation to intergenerational continuity.

Through LuLing's amnesia and her writing against it, and through Ruth's eventual rediscovery of her mother's story, Tan explores memory as a layered, ironic, and ethically charged phenomenon, as Ruth observes, "Dementia was like a truth serum" (Tan, 2001, p.308). The act of recalling and narrativizing past experiences functions as a defensive mechanism that enables both mother and daughter to integrate the self within the dislocating context of diasporic America. For LuLing, amnesia becomes as a form of constructive forgetting, a therapeutic negotiation with trauma that facilitates emotional and cultural reconciliation. In revisiting her past, she selectively recalls moments of love and intimacy rather than grief, insisting, she "only recalls being loved very, very much" (Tan, 2001, p.351). Through writing, she performs the oscillation between erasure and remembrance: forgetting as a survival strategy, while remembrance as an effort toward continuity. Her experience exemplifies a diasporic ethics of recovery, wherein selective memory assumes both aesthetic and moral significance. Ruth, in turn, stops her job as a ghostwriter for others, and engages in her own act of creative writing, with the insights gleaned from her mother's memories to reimagine her own identity and future. As Preselfannie McDaniels (2004) observes, dialogic exchanges of stories between mothers and daughters constitutes a vital practice of identity formation, allowing daughters to comprehend their mothers' struggles and, in turn, to reclaim aspects of heritage that had been silenced (p.128). While initially fearful of rewriting her life and the past, she comes to recognize writing as a means to process, reinterpret, and reconcile with both her family history and her own selfhood, as the novel describes, "the idea of revising her life also frightened her, as if by imagination alone she were condemning what she did not like about herself or others. Writing what you wished was the most dangerous form of wishful thinking (Tan, 2001, p.31).

Survival in the diasporic environment requires effective mechanisms for articulating and preserving memory. The process, however, is never straightforward. As Cynthia Wong (2008) argues, the generational and cultural gaps between mother and daughter expose the inherent tension in translating lived experience across time, language, and perception. Tan's frequent shifts in narrative perspective underscore the fluidity of memory and show how personal and collective histories, alongside subjective interpretations, continuously intersect (p.64). Storytelling becomes a crucial mode for negotiating these gaps. Both LuLing and Ruth gradually realize that the durability of their ancestral stories stems from their capacity to change over time, and they both integrate such transformations

into their own lives by writing and reinterpreting. As LuLing's translator, Mr. Tang explains, "So much of history is a mystery. We don't know what is lost forever, what will surface again. All objects exist in a moment of time. And that fragment of time is preserved or lost or found in mysterious ways'" (Tan, 2001, p.396). This view highlights the mediated nature of memory. That is to say, stories are never simply recorded, rather, they are interpreted, reconstructed, and occasionally imagined. Both LuLing and Ruth confront the paradox, questioning whether a told story is necessarily a true story. Tan herself articulates this ethos of reclamation in her memoir *The Opposite of Fate* (2003): "We know the past can be changed. We can choose what we should believe. We can choose what we should remember. That is what frees us" (Tan, 2003, p.104). By the novel's conclusion, Ruth stands on the threshold of her own creative work. She intends to weave together the told and the imagined in order to produce a narrative that honors the lives and memories of her mother and grandfather. Her writing will actively reintegrate gaps, silence, and fragments, creating a living archive of diasporic experience, as the novel's conclusion describes:

> They write about what happened, why it happened, how they can make other things happen. They write stories of things that are but should not have been. They write about what could have been, what still might be. They write of a past that can be changed. [. . .] They know where happiness lies, not in a cave or a country, but in love and the freedom to give and take what has been there all along. Ruth remembers this as she writes a story. It is for her grandmother, for herself, for the little girl who became her mother. (Tan, 2001, p.197)

Memory, as Carol Boyce Davis (1998) argues, transcends temporal, history, and spatial boundaries, offering a means of articulating new meanings and creating coherence within the fragmented experiences of diaspora (p.1006). Extending Davis' insight, diasporic literature treats acts of remembrance as critical responses to cultural erasure, creative processes that reshape the past through the interpretive consciousness of the present. In Amy Tan's writing, as Cynthia Wong (2008) notes, storytelling denotes both a literary genre and a mode of imaginative reconstruction through which characters fill the silences and gaps in their historical and cultural narratives: "such 'making up' helps the artificer move through the corridors of memory" (p.75). By interweaving the personal stories of women across different moments of Chinese diasporic experience, Tan enacts what David E. Apter (1993, as cited in Wong, 2008) describes as the intertwined processes of truth-telling and storytelling: "truth telling and storytelling are part of the same process by which it becomes possible to interrogate the past in order to transform the future" (p.207). Through this interplay of memory, imagination, and narrative reconstruction, storytelling in *The Bonesetter's Daughter* emerges as both ethical practice and aesthetic strategy. It allows diasporic subjects to preserve, reinterpret, and reclaim their cultural inheritance. Ben Xu (1994) similarly notes that narrative memory is not just a recounting of life stories but a reflective act that reconstitutes experience within the consciousness of the present self (p.4). Storytelling thus is a vital mode through which Chinese American mothers and daughters bridge generational divides, reconstruct cultural lineage, and resist the dissolution of cultural memory.

Viewed in this light, the narrative strategies of Chinese diasporic writers can be understood as deliberate interventions against forgetting. Writing and storytelling operate as counter-discursive practices that confront the active or passive erosion of ethnic memory, whether through migration, assimilation, or the historical marginalization. By reconstructing cultural heritage through both oral and written modes, these narratives expand readers' awareness of Chinese diasporic histories while simultaneously legitimizing the cultural identities of displaced communities. More importantly, they transform narration itself into a vehicle for intergenerational transmission, through which memory and identity are continually renewed. *The Bonesetter's Daughter* emphasizes how the written text complements, rather than replaces, oral transmission. LuLing's manuscript, composed amid her Alzheimer's-induced amnesia, becomes simultaneously as personal testament and material archive that safeguards ancestral memory when verbal communication falters. Within diasporic contexts, such documentation becomes a critical defense against the encroachment of amnesia, ensuring that stories of migration, struggle, and resilience remain inscribed within collective consciousness and transmitted across generations.

Tracing Forgotten Memories: Falling Leaves Returning to the Root

In juxtaposition, Tan and Zhang explore how memory mediates the interrelation between cultural identity and familial inheritance, articulating convergent strategies for representing the transmission of the past across generations. In each narrative, the maternal figures embody a paradoxical form of resilience, and defend cultural identities even as memory loss erodes their grasp of the present. Though cognitive decline blurs immediate experience, both retain vivid recollections of their cultural origins, especially those rooted in kinship and collective memory. Paradoxically, the mothers' amnesia heightens the urgency of cultural transmission, as cognitive fragility compels them to preserve heritage through linguistic, narrative, and material acts of remembrance. Both authors employ tangible artifacts as mnemonic vessels that mediate between the living and the dead, the remembered and the forgotten. Through these material traces, their daughters recover suppressed histories and reassemble fragmented identities within the broader framework of diasporic inheritance. While if *The Bonesetter's Daughter* locates remembrance in the intimate act of writing, where the maternal voice is transcribed, translated and reanimated through language, then *Gold Mountain Blues* extends this inquiry into the realm of collective history. Zhang situates the family story within a transnational and historical framework, tracing how diasporic subjects reconstruct belonging through acts of return and ancestral re-engagement.

In *Gold Mountain Blues*, Amy's journey to uncover her family's past contrasts sharply with her mother Yin Ling's lifelong pursuit of assimilation. Amy's mixed heritage and Western upbringing leave her detached from her Chinese origins. As a sociology professor at the University of British Columbia, she appears to embody her mother's long-cherished aspiration toward Western modernity. When questioned about her interest in the local culture of her ancestral hometown, she promptly disavows any such attachment: "I'm interested in any sociological phenomena [. . .] whether it's over here or back home, there is no difference" (Zhang, 2017, p.6). This remark reveals a subjectivity shaped by the tension between her maternal Chinese heritage and her Western lived experience, while simultaneously dissolving the boundary between homeland and foreign land. Initially, her decision to travel to ancestral home in Guangdong province seems less on a heartfelt quest for cultural roots than a dutiful fulfillment of her mother's final wish. Her dismissive response to her boyfriend's suggestion that the journey might reconnect with her roots: "When you're someone like me with a zero for a father and a zero-point-five of a mother, and the roots you've got are in half an inch of poor soil on a rock, there's nothing much to see. What's the point of looking for more roots?" (Zhang, 2017, pp.413–414), encapsulates her skepticism toward the possibility of meaningful reclamation of cultural heritage.

However, Amy's perspective shifts as she steps into her family's ancestral home. The *diulau*, a traditional clan house that fuses Eastern and Western architectural elements, materializes as a tangible emblem of the cultural hybridity. Within its weathered walls, Amy encounters the traces of her ancestors' lives: ancestral tablets, worn silk jackets, an ivory opium pipe, and yellowed letters. Each object, silent yet evocative, serves as a mnemonic trigger, awakening in her long-suppressed sense of belonging. In alignment with French philosopher Gaston Bachelard's (1994) concept of the house as a "synthesis of immemorial and recollected" space (p.5), the *diulau* becomes a living archive where memory and imagination coalesce, transforming the relic of the past into a site affective renewal. Through her engagement with historical documents, especially a collection of letters exchanged between her grandparents, Amy gradually comes to grasp the endurance, aspiration, and love of early Chinese immigrant families. This encounter with the past transforms her initial sense of displacement into a deeper understanding of her cultural inheritance. Furthermore, among these relics, a childhood photograph of her mother cradled in her grandmother's arms stands out as a moment of profound revelation. The accumulated weight of familial history becomes tangible, and Amy begins to perceive a sense of continuity where she had once seen rupture. The photograph's material intimacy repositions her within a larger genealogy, compelling Amy to recognize that she, too, possesses deep roots and an integral position within a lineage long effaced by migration and

silence (Zhang, 2017, p.414). This intergenerational resonance exemplifies what Marianne Hirsch's (1997) terms postmemory: the phenomenon by which the children of those marked trauma inherit the psychic weight of events they did not directly witness. Through mediated forms such as storytelling and photography, these descendants internalize both the burden of remembrance and the anxiety of forgetting, revealing how personal engagement with family archives operates within a transgenerational field of memory.

This awakening catalyzes Amy's resolve to honor and reanimate her family's legacy through ritual and commemoration. By erecting a memorial tablet and holding her wedding ceremony within the ancestral *diulau*, she transforms private remembrance into a public affirmation of identity. The *diulau* evolves from a decaying architectural remnant into a living site of cultural renewal, where memory becomes materially and ceremonially inscribed. Drawing on German folklorist Jan Assmann's (2011) insight that cultural memory is sustained through ritualized acts that guarantee the continuity of identity (p.20). Amy's commemorative acts can be read as attempts to restore this continuum of belonging. Moreover, Amy, originally hesitant about marriage, chooses to hold her wedding ceremony within the ancestral *diulau*. This decision, in her fifties, marks not only a personal milestone but also a symbolic act of reconnecting with her heritage, bridging the past and present through ritual, place, and narrative. Her return to the ancestral home thereby signifies not only a geographical and genealogical reconnection but also an epistemological reclamation of selfhood. Through this process, Amy ultimately embraces her hybrid inheritance, "acknowledging to the whole world that she is half Chinese" (Zhang, 2017, p.517). This affirmation transcends the binary of assimilation versus authenticity, instead articulating a diasporic identity grounded in multiplicity and relational continuity. In reclaiming her family's stories and re-inscribing them within both personal and collective memory, Amy heals her own dislocation while symbolically restores the voices of those erased from dominant historical narratives.

It is notable that Zhang's novel tends to be driven by an archival impulse: it anchors identity in historical documentation and verifiable lineage. Her narrative transforms memory into an act of historical reclamation that resists national amnesia and restores Chinese immigrants' silenced presence within Canada's collective past. Memory here stabilizes identity by embedding the individual within a sociohistorical continuum marked by migration and endurance. As Zhang Ling herself explains in the preface, the novel arose from two formative encounters that shaped her imaginative engagement with Chinese Canadian history. The first occurred in 1986, when, during her travels in Canada, she unexpectedly came across the gravestones of early Chinese immigrant laborers. This encounter sparked her determination to write about these long-silenced lives. The second took place in 2003, when Zhang, participating in a cultural exchange program for overseas Chinese writers, visited *diulau*, the "fortress homes" built in Guangdong with remittances from Chinese laborers aboard to safeguard the women and children they had left behind (Zhang, 2017, pp.vii-viii). Confronted with these material traces of migration and separation, Zhang felt an urgent need to recover the erased history of the Chinese diaspora, one that encompasses both the sojourners who ventured to the "Gold Mountain" and the families who remained behind in the *diulau* of southern China. The narrative of the Fong family thus embodies an intricate network of intertwined memories that traverse geographical and historical boundaries. On one hand, it mirrors the collective experiences of early Chinese laborers in Canada: the gold miners, railway builders, plantation workers, and domestic servants whose labor underpinned the nation's early development yet remained largely unacknowledged. On the other, it unfolds against the grand canvas of modern Chinese history, encompassing events such as the Opium Wars, the Reform Movement of 1898, the Second Sino-Japanese War (1937–45), and the founding of the People's Republic of China in 1949. This temporal layering transforms the family saga into an intertextual dialogue between history and memory, achieving a profound "historical embeddedness" that illustrate how diasporic identity is continuously reconstructed through the interaction of individual, familial and collective histories (Pu and Song, 2012, p.48).

To ground her narrative in historical authenticity, Zhang conducted extensive archival and field research, citing a range of reference materials at the end of the novel. The process of writing the novel,

as Zhang recalls, was "an all-consuming journey, digging into the rock-hard crust of history" (Zhang, 2017, p.ix). As literary critic Pei-yin Lin (2014) observes, the novel's intuitive mode of historical narration performs two main functions. First, it grants the early Chinese laborers a long-denied opportunity for individual expression, transforming their century-old struggles abroad into a bottom-up narrative that foregrounds "history from below" (p.118). By centering the Fong family, Zhang reclaims the individuality of those subsumed by grand historical narrative, effectively writing biographies for the historical forgotten. At the outset of the story, when Amy asks why the home village appears so desolate, the guide wryly responds, "Do you want the textbook answer or the local tales?" (Zhang, 2017, p.7). What Zhang ultimately presents is neither version; rather, she offers a new approach that synthesizes the vivid immediacy of oral history with analytic rigor and coherence of written historiography. Second, Zhang intertwines historical documentation with a plot-driven narrative that resonates with the conventions of popular drama. The rhetorical techniques of popular storytelling render the sweeping historical scope more accessible and emotionally engaging for readers, while the quasi-realistic representation of historical events provides both political and aesthetic enrichment, enhancing the novel's authenticity as a historiographical as well as literary text (Lin, 2014, p.119). Through the dual act of remembrance and re-inscription, *Gold Mountain Blues* not only dramatizes the psychic and cultural challenges of diasporic self-recovery but also restores marginalized Chinese immigrant narratives to the broader fabric of Canadian national memory. Upon completing the novel, Zhang Ling reflected that it brought her "a profound sense of peace," having "given voice to a group of people buried in the dark abyss of history for more than a century, silent and forgotten" (Zhang, 2017, p.x).

Zhang and Tan converge in exploring how memory, history, and identity intersect within the diasporic condition, albeit through divergent yet complementary approaches. Whereas Zhang emphasizes archival reconstruction and historical fidelity, Tan privileges emotional memory and affective truth as a vehicle for remembering and relational repair. In *The Bonesetter's Daughter*, Tan foregrounds what she terms "emotional memory," a form of recollection shaped by affective truth rather than empirical accuracy. As she observes, the remembered past in her fiction inhabits a "fictive home" where "anything can happen," and where the emotional experiences of the past continue to shape the present and the future (Tan, 2003, p.109). Memory functions as both aesthetic and psychological reconstruction, a mechanism through which mother and daughter reforge intimacy across the ruptures of forgetting. Reflecting on her creative practice, Tan likens writing to opening "a tomb of memories," imagining the past anew to confront pain and uncover what endures. She explains, "We open it and release what has be buried for too long – the terrible despair, the destructive rage. We hurt, we grieve, we cry. And then we see what remains: the hopes, broken to bits but still there" (Tan, 2003, p.104). Through this evocative imagery, Tan redefines remembrance as a transformative act of mourning and renewal, one in which inherited trauma is actively transmuted into creative survival.

Despite the different emphasis and narrative strategies, both author approaches ultimately illuminate the ethical and epistemological stakes of memory in diasporic contexts. In Zhang, memory functions as an epistemological stabilizer; in Tan, as an affective catalyst. The former reconstructs history; the latter reanimates emotion. Both, however, converge in their recognition of memory as an ethical practice through which diasporic women reclaim agency over selfhood and history. As Edward Said (2000) explains, diasporic consciousness emerges through a dialectic between individual recollection and collective history, enabling displaced subjects to maintain cultural rootedness amid conditions of exile and dispersion (p.177). Within this framework, both authors engage in mnemonic resistance: the strategic use of memory to contest the erasures imposed by colonial and national narratives. Their works transform personal remembrance into a site of cultural endurance, reaffirming the vitality of Chinese diasporic identity in transnational modernity. As cultural theorist Andreas Huyssen (1995) argues, minority writers destabilize dominant cultural memory by foregrounding multiplicity and instability (p.252). Tan and Zhang redefine memory as a living, dialogic process that continually negotiates between history and emotion, continuity and rupture, the inherited and the reimagined.

Conclusion

Through a comparative reading of *The Bonesetter's Daughter* and *Gold Mountain Blues*, this article has shown how amnesia functions as a metaphor through which diasporic experience is inscribed, fractured, and reimagined. In both novels, Alzheimer's disease serves as symptom and narrative device, being an emblem of cultural trauma and a means of its partial recuperation. The afflicted mothers embody the dialectic of forgetting and remembering that structures diasporic subjectivity: they are at once preservers and erasers of the past, figures whose cognitive decline exposes both the fragility of cultural transmission and the persistence of ancestral memory beneath its erasures. The oscillation between forgetting and remembering shapes the emotional and narrative architecture of both works. In *The Bonesetter's Daughter*, writing becomes both prosthesis and resistance: a compensatory act against neurological decay and a means of preserving identity against the assimilative erasures of migration. *Gold Mountain Blues*, by contrast, situates memory loss within a broader historical continuum, tracing the dispersal and reconfiguration of Chinese identities across generations. By restoring erased Chinese presences to the Canadian national imaginary, the novel reterritorializes remembrance within the geography of diaspora. Material traces, including letters, photographs, and ancestral spaces, become mnemonic anchors through which continuity persists despite colonial and migratory ruptures. Moreover, the mothers' fading recollections compel their daughters to reconstruct meaning, to translate absence into presence, and to recover belonging through acts of narrative reconstitution. Forgetting, these novels suggest, is not the negation of memory but its condition of possibility, a necessary clearing through which new inscriptions of self and culture may emerge. Amnesia thus becomes a threshold rather than an end: a liminal state through which forgotten histories, silenced voices, and buried emotions resurface. In reclaiming what has been lost through language, storytelling, and intergenerational understanding, Tan and Zhang reveal that within erasure lies the seed of remembrance, and within forgetting, the quiet persistence of return.

Note

1. *Gold Mountain Blues* was first published in Chinese in 2009 by Beijing October Literature and Arts Publishing House, 2009; The first English edition, translated by Nicky Harman, was published in Canada by Viking in 2011. This article cities the revised second English edition, published by Corvus in 2017.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This work is supported by the Hubei Federation of Social Science Associations under the Special Project "Jingchu Culture and Its International Communication" (Grant No. JCWHZD2025103).

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